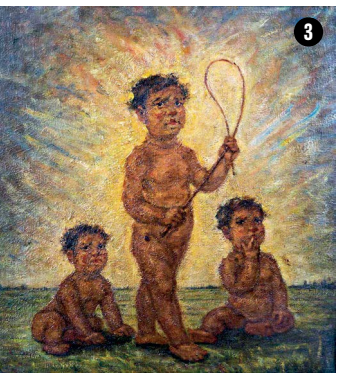
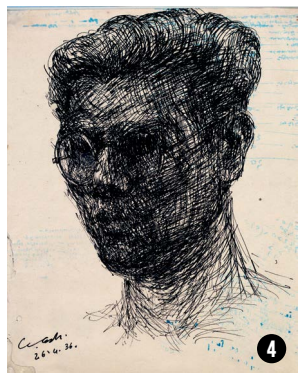




A RICH OEUVRE
1. 'Ploughing', 1940
2. 'Fisherman', 1939
3. *Commander-in-Chief* children series, 1957-67
4. Self portrait, 1936
5. Gobardhan Ash (left) and Ganesh Pyne





EXHIBITION

Rebel with a CAUSE

A retrospective of revolutionary artist **Gobardhan Ash** showcases four decades of his practice at the Kolkata Centre for Creativity



Slices of forgotten Calcutta, deep meditative paintings of nature, politically strident art as protest, and a wonderfully intriguing *Avatar* series with "pattachitra idioms" are seen in this uncommon exhibition featuring over 100 works by the late, and often overlooked, artist Gobardhan Ash. Curated by Brijeshwari Kumari Gohil and Harsharan Bakshi, *The Prinseps Exhibition: Gobardhan Ash Retrospective*, is on till April 21 at the Kolkata Centre for Creativity.

Born in 1907 to a family of humble means in Begumpur in Bengal's Hooghly district, Ash's "knack for art" was discovered early on during his days in high school. The exhibition traces the journey of his life through his art—right from when he ran away to the Benares Art School and his coerced return to Calcutta where he eventually enrolled in the Government School of Art where among other awards and accolades he also attracted notice from Jamini Roy, to his continued defiance against the then "regimented British academic mode of teaching".

His commitment to true creative expression is further highlighted through his rebel phase when he formed the Young Artist Union in 1931 and after leaving the Government School of Art (with Abani Sen, Annada Dey and Digin Bhattacharya) in 1933 when he formed the Art Rebel Centre.

One of the most intriguing phases of Ash's oeuvre is entitled the *Avatar* series mainly created between 1948-1951 that poet and art critic Ranjit Hoskote describes as weaving "various idioms of pattachitra into a consciousness that is clearly aware of cinema and animation". Gohil likens these pictures to "little character studies with a certain primitivism and rawness. Unlike his other work, which is often documenting history, whether it is through the landscapes or the Bengal famine, this has an element of distortion." Created long before digital media and "avatars or profile pictures" came about, Gohil interprets this particular series as "his digital imprint in the art world".

Ash was considered to have "wielded considerable influence" by the famous theatre director and art collector Ebrahim Alkazi. Many of the displays in the exhibition proclaim Ash's meditations upon his artmaking. One of these says, "Even if it's with just a *batasha* as an offering, you have to pray to God. I pray thus by making a sketch every morning. It makes my day. I might create several pictures after that. But whether I do so or not, sleep, or do whatever I please, it doesn't matter." Words to live by for any art practitioner. ■

–Malini Banerjee